

What does a handoff cost a service desk?

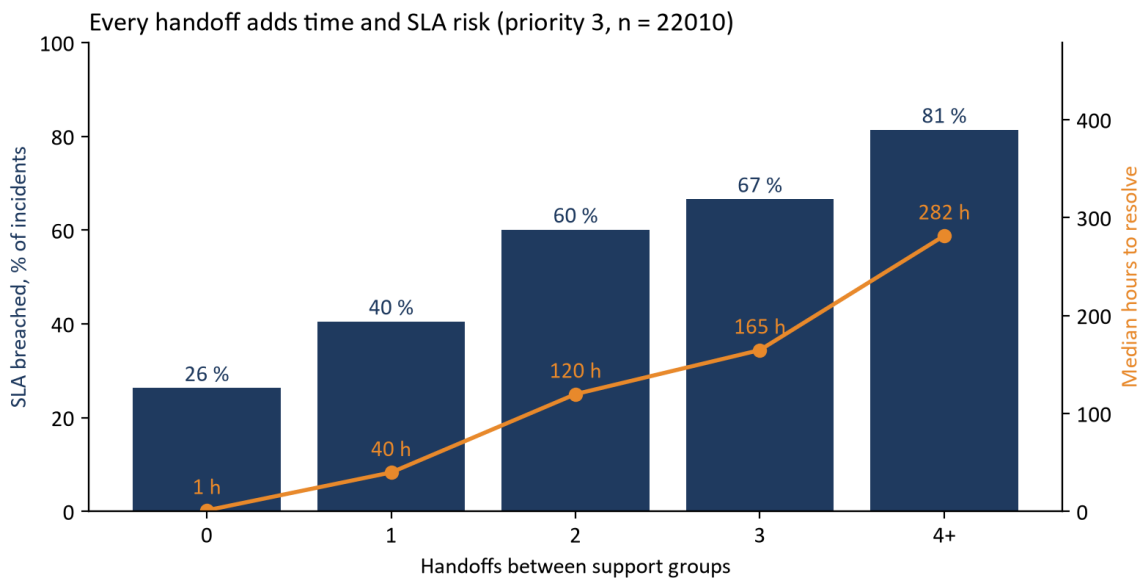
SQL analysis of a public IT incident log: 141 712 events, 24 918 incidents (ServiceNow export, UCI no. 498, CC BY 4.0). Personal project, October 2026.

QUESTION

How much do handoffs between support groups cost in resolution time and SLA, and is ping-pong (a return to an earlier group) worse than a handoff to a new group?

WHAT I DID

Typed the raw event log and rebuilt, in SQL with window functions and CTEs, each incident's path through support groups. Compared medians and SLA breaches by number of handoffs (priority 3 only), compared ping-pong with forward-only paths at the same number of handoffs, and wrote 11 ITIL process and data rules as SQL checks. Verified the headline numbers with an independent recount from the raw file.



RESULTS

- Solved by the first group: median 1 hour, SLA breached in 26 %. With 4 or more handoffs: 282 hours and 81 %.
- Ping-pong looks worse only because bounced incidents have more handoffs. At the same count the results are almost equal (2 handoffs: 60 % vs 60 % breached).
- The tool enforces its own logic (priority matrix, timestamps, SLA flag are clean), but 6.2 % of closed incidents carry no resolution time and drop out of every report.

WHAT IT MEANS

First-group resolution is the cheapest outcome; routing to the right group sooner matters more than forbidding returns; the resolution time should be mandatory at closure.

TOOLS

SQL (SQLite: window functions, CTEs), Python for loading and charts.